



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: St. Stephen's Classical Christian Academy

School Website: <https://ststephensclassical.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

St. Stephen's Classical Christian Academy (SSCCA) in Eldersburg, Maryland embodies a robust Classical Christian program, with explicit integration of the Trivium (Grammar, Logic, Rhetoric), a strong emphasis on Great Books and the Great Conversation, and a clearly articulated Christian worldview woven through curriculum, pedagogy, and community life. Public materials consistently frame education as formation of character and mind, centered in truth, goodness, and beauty, anchored by Scripture and prayer. The school presents itself as a parish-based classical school with a mission to develop disciples of Christ, training minds and forming hearts, and it foregrounds virtue, curriculum alignment to the liberal arts, and a partnership with families. On balance, SSCCA aligns with a CLASSICAL classification across all six categories: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations; Purpose and Goal; Curriculum; Pedagogy; Faculty; and Parents & Community.

Key evidence includes: (1) explicit Mission statements emphasizing forming hearts and training minds in a Christian frame, grounded in Biblical truth; (2) a rigorous Classical model centered on the Trivium, Great Books, and historical study across the curriculum; (3) explicit description of lower- and upper-school pedagogy that blends singing/chanting and memory work in early grades with Socratic inquiry, debate, and rhetoric in upper grades; (4) a faculty culture described as mentors within a living curriculum; (5) a strong, ongoing emphasis on parent partnership within a parish-community setting; and (6) clear alignment with a Christian worldview throughout governance and community life. See cited materials from SSCCA's site, including Mission statements, Classical Model, Biblical Basis, Curriculum descriptions, and Academy Distinctions.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The mission explicitly states: "The mission of SSCCA is to develop disciples of the Lord Jesus Christ through training minds and forming hearts." - Public materials describe Classical education through a Christian worldview, teaching "in the light of a Christian worldview" and grounding truth, goodness, and beauty in Scripture. - Daily prayer/reflection and Scripture-centered instruction are repeatedly highlighted (Biblically Based / Biblically infused curriculum).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: God, truth, goodness, beauty, Scripture, Christ/Christian, prayer, liturgical/communal prayer, Imago Dei, Christian worldview, virtuous disciples. - Negative keywords present: None apparent in public materials.

Frequency and Rating - Positive keywords observed: 8+ distinct indicators; Negative: 0. - Conclusion: CLASSICAL

Why this rating - SSCCA foregrounds transcendental ideals (truth, goodness, beauty) rooted in Scripture, with liturgical prayer and Christian community life. This aligns squarely with a religious/metaphysical foundation that is central to classical schools of this tradition.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Mission emphasizes forming disciples and shaping hearts/minds within a Biblical framework. - The school presents education as formation of virtue and wisdom, not solely vocational preparation, and asserts a belief in truth, goodness, and beauty as knowable. - The Classical model sections frame education as mastery and formation, not mere information, with explicit virtues-based aims.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: virtue, wisdom, formation, disciples, truth, goodness, beauty, human excellence, mind/heart formation, Christian worldview. - Negative keywords present: None explicit.

Frequency and Rating - Positive keywords observed: 7+; Negative: 0. - Conclusion: CLASSICAL

Why this rating - The public-facing materials consistently articulate education as formation toward virtue and wisdom, anchored in a Christian worldview, with a goal of forming humans capable of truth-guided discernment rather than a narrow job-prep narrative.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The Trivium is central: Grammar, Logic, and Rhetoric are described as stages. - History is organized as a curriculum through history and Great Books; the program references the Great Conversation and Great Books of Western Civilization. - Specific grade-band articulation (Grammar Stage, Logic Stage, Rhetoric Stage) with content areas (Latin, logic, composition, literature) is described. - Explicit focus on Great Books and Christian Tradition as part of the curriculum. - Emphasis on memorization, chanting, and the cultivation of wonder within the curriculum (lower grammar materials).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: Trivium (Grammar/Logic/Rhetoric), Great Books / Great Conversation, Western Civilization, Christian Tradition, Latin, memorization/recitation, history chronology, wonder. - Negative keywords present: None evident.

Frequency and Rating - Positive keywords observed: 8+; Negative: 0. - Conclusion: CLASSICAL

Why this rating - The curriculum is explicitly built around classical content and methods (Trivium; Great Books; historical continuum; grammar/logic/rhetoric progression) with a Christian lens, matching the core criteria for a classical curriculum.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Lower School pedagogy includes singing, chanting, recitation, and memory work, with guided discovery and tactile learning (Grammar Stage approaches). - Upper School pedagogy features Socratic discussions, debates, time lines, formal logic, and research projects to develop critical thinking and rhetoric. - The program emphasizes contemplative/restful elements as part of a balanced approach, alongside rigorous study.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: singing/chanting, recitation, memory, guided discovery, debates, Socratic discussion, rhetoric, logic, public speaking, research projects, seminars, time lines. - Negative keywords present: None explicit.

Frequency and Rating - Positive keywords observed: 9+; Negative: 0. - Conclusion: CLASSICAL

Why this rating - Pedagogy aligns with classical principles: experiential, chant/memory work in the Grammar stage; Socratic inquiry and rhetoric in the Logic/Rhetoric stages; explicit use of debate, seminars, and public-speaking opportunities in upper grades. This is a hallmark of classical teaching methods.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The site presents teachers as model mentors who form part of the “living curriculum” and core of the school, with an emphasis on virtue, skill, and knowledge. - The mission and history emphasize teachers who love the Lord and teach from a Christian worldview, contributing to an environment where students

grow in wisdom and virtue. - Governance and accountability are described via a school board that protects the mission and fosters trust with families. - Acknowledgment of teacher quality and curriculum alignment across grade levels is evident in admissions and history materials.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: model teachers, mentors, living curriculum, core of the school, teachers who love the Lord, Christian worldview, mission-driven governance (board stewardship). - Negative keywords present: None explicit.

Frequency and Rating - Positive keywords observed: 6+; Negative: 0. - Conclusion: CLASSICAL

Why this rating - The site repeatedly frames faculty as virtuous, knowledgeable mentors who embody and deliver the curriculum, with governance and board oversight aligned to protect mission. This aligns with the classical model's emphasis on faculty as the living embodiment of the school's aims.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school emphasizes partnership with parents as co-teachers and a nurturing community of parents and teachers who share a commitment to virtuous learning; tours and open houses are encouraged, and families are welcome to visits. - Academy distinctions highlight a community of parents and teachers and a parish setting that supports lifelong learning and godliness. - Location and parish affiliation are described to emphasize communal life and accessibility for families; open tours and admissions processes invite parental involvement. - Governance emphasizes transparency and parental involvement through the Board, reinforcing parent-school partnership.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with parents, co-teaching, nurturing community, parent involvement, open visits, parish setting, schedule a tour/open house. - Negative keywords present: None explicit.

Frequency and Rating - Positive keywords observed: 6+; Negative: 0. - Conclusion: CLASSICAL

Why this rating - The materials depict parents as active partners in education, with explicit language about co-teaching roles, parental involvement opportunities, and a welcoming culture for family engagement. This is consistent with classical schools that emphasize community and formation within a shared mission.

What Would Move the Needle

No major needle-moving changes are required. SSCCA already demonstrates a cohesive CLASSICAL alignment across all six categories, including explicit Christian formation, Trivium-based curriculum, Great Books orientation, Socratic and rhetoric-focused pedagogy, faculty as mentors, and strong parental/community engagement. To move beyond CLASSICAL to a more holistic, ultra-explicit "absolutely classical" standard in future iterations, the school could consider: - More explicit mapping of Great Books selections and discussion prompts across all grades to demonstrate a continuous Great Conversation chain. - A formal, published "living curriculum" document linking teachable moments in each subject to the Trivium stages and to virtue-based outcomes, ensuring uniformity across grade cohorts. - A more explicit articulation of "scholé" or contemplative practices in daily routines to foreground contemplative rest as a unique classical practice, in addition to active Socratic inquiry.

Note: The above would be additive refinements; current materials already reflect CLASSICAL alignment.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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